

## ShiftED AI — Goal Establishment Guide (why the coach must agree goals before moving on)

**Meeting:** ShiftED AI weekly, 8 July 2026

**Decision:** The AI must establish a **clear goal and key steps** with the user before moving to later parts of the conversation.

**Prepared for:** Simon, Kara, Louise, trainers, and developers

### Why this document exists

Simon identified a real problem in live testing: the coach sometimes moved on to conversation techniques, homework, or skills **before** the user had a clear picture of what they were working toward. Without a specific outcome, sessions feel directionless and users get distracted.

This guide explains — in normal language — exactly what must happen, what the coach should say, and what "done" looks like. Use it to review, test, and comment before we lock the behaviour in the live system.

### The core rule (say this in the meeting)

**No tactics until there is a target.**

That means:

- No homework
- No skill recommendations (boundary work, thought records, etc.)
- No "try this experiment tomorrow"
- No Phase Three check-ins on actions that were never properly agreed

...until the user has confirmed their understanding of the situation (Phase One handshake) **and** agreed what success looks like plus at least one concrete step toward it.

### The full gate sequence (what must be true before each next step)

**Gate A — Before any micro-goal or homework**

| # | Requirement        | Plain English                                                                          | How we know it's done                     |
|---|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Phase One complete | User confirmed the coach's summary of their situation, trigger, beliefs, and reactions | User said yes to the reflective handshake |

| # | Requirement           | Plain English                                               | How we know it's done                                         |
|---|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2 | Target outcome stated | User named what success would look like in observable terms | Not "feel better" — something you could see or hear           |
| 3 | Key steps named       | At least one concrete move toward that outcome              | e.g. "Book 20 minutes with Alex";<br>"Draft opening sentence" |

### Gate B — Before execution coaching (every return visit)

| # | Requirement            | Plain English                                                          |
|---|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4 | One micro-goal locked  | A single action that fits in <b>one day</b> or <b>one sitting</b>      |
| 5 | Confidence $\geq 7/10$ | User rates tomorrow confidence at 7 or above; if below, step is shrunk |

### Gate C — Before development skills (action tools)

| # | Requirement                                                                         |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6 | Gates A and B satisfied and user is not in distress recovery (Sustainability Pivot) |

If someone just failed a step and is flooded, **calm first** (core skill), **re-check assumptions**, then **smaller step** — don't pile on new skills.

## Step-by-step: what the coach does in Phase Two

### Step 2.0 — Goal establishment (new — from 8 July meeting)

#### Turn 1 — Outcome question

Ask what success looks like. Reject vague answers.

- **Good:** "If this went as well as it could, what would you see or do differently?"
- **Weak:** Accepting "I'd feel less stressed" without narrowing.
- **Follow-up if vague:** "What would actually be happening in the room — or in your calendar — if that went well?"

#### Turn 2 — Key steps question

Ask for the first steps **they** see, not steps the coach invents.

- **Good:** "What's the first step you'd need to take to move toward that?"
- **Good (second step later):** "What would come after that — still keeping it small?"

**Do not proceed** to skill names, thought challenging, or homework until at least one key step is on the table.

### Step 2.1 — Lock the target outcome

Repeat the outcome in **their words**. Tie it quietly to what came out of Phase One (fears, rules) without saying "Phase One."

**Example:** "So the outcome you're aiming for is a 20-minute conversation where Alex explains what's blocking the deadlines — not a blame session. Is that the target?"

## Step 2.2 — Shrink to a micro-goal

The first committed action must be doable **tomorrow** in one sitting.

**Downscaling ladder (internal — coach thinks this, doesn't lecture about it):**

1. Full task (too big?)
2. One-hour slice
3. Fifteen-minute slice
4. Two-minute approach (e.g. open calendar, draft one sentence)
5. Environment prep only

**Boundary example:** One element per turn — "What would you actually say to open that conversation?"

**Behavioural activation example:** When + where + what exactly — "When tomorrow could you block 20 minutes, and where?"

## Step 2.3 — Confidence check

**Exact question:** "On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you that you can do this tomorrow?"

| Answer | Coach response                                                                                                |
|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7–10   | Lock it. Mention it will appear on their Tasks page. Move to check-in mode on next login.                     |
| 4–6    | "Let's make it smaller — what's a half-size version you could still try tomorrow?" Then ask confidence again. |
| 1–3    | One calming skill (distancing). Then: "What's the smallest possible first move — even 2 minutes?"             |

## What the coach should do when users push ahead

| User behaviour                     | Coach response (pattern)                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Just tell me what to say to Alex" | "I want to get you something practical — first, what would 'good' look like if that conversation went well?" |
| "Can we do a thought record?"      | "We can — before that, are we agreed on what you're trying to achieve in that situation?"                    |
| "I already know the problem"       | "You've named the situation clearly — what would you want to be different by the end of next week?"          |
| Agrees outcome but no steps        | "What's one thing you could do in the next 24 hours that moves you toward that?"                             |
| Confidence 5/10                    | Halve the step. Do not add a second skill in the same message.                                               |

## Example conversation (good flow)

**User:** My direct report Alex missed two deadlines and I keep putting off the conversation.

**Coach (Phase 1.1):** "Putting off that talk with Alex sounds heavy — when was the last time you almost brought it up but didn't?"

... (Phase 1.2 elements, one per turn: trigger, rule, belief, strength, coping) ...

**Coach (handshake):** "So when the deadline slipped, you read it as Alex not caring — around 80% — and you went quiet and sent a short email instead. Does that capture it?"

**User:** Yeah, that's basically it.

**Coach (2.0 outcome):** "If you handled this as well as you realistically could, what would be different after the conversation?"

**User:** I'd understand what's actually blocking him and we'd agree what happens next.

**Coach (2.0 steps):** "What's the first step you'd take toward that — still before the full conversation?"

**User:** Book 20 minutes with him this week.

**Coach (2.3 confidence):** "On 1–10, how confident are you that you'll book that tomorrow?"

**User:** 8.

**Coach:** "Good — book that 20 minutes tomorrow and we'll check how it went when you're back. I've added that to your Tasks list."

## Example conversation (bad flow — do not do this)

**User:** Alex missed deadlines and I'm stressed.

**Coach (bad):** "Let's run a behavioural experiment — try writing a new thought and test it with a colleague tomorrow."

→ **Why bad:** No handshake, no outcome, no micro-goal, confidence not checked.

**Coach (bad):** "Was it a formal complaint, and what was the outcome? How does that influence your expectations for Alex?"

→ **Why bad:** Two questions in one message (Simon feedback).

## Connection to the Tasks page

When the coach agrees something the user should do before next chat, that item must appear on the **Tasks** page as a tickable goal. Examples:

- "Book 20 min with Alex — Tuesday morning"
- "Draft one opening sentence that acknowledges workload"

The coach should use the user's names and situation — never generic labels like "Set a micro-goal."

Users can also add their own tasks manually. Coach-suggested tasks and user tasks live on the same list.

## How trainers should test this

1. **New journey** — Coach must not assign homework before handshake + outcome.
2. **Same test sentence** — Simon and Nikki type the same opening; both should get a **goal-clarification** move at the same stage (wording may differ because of mirroring).
3. **Tasks panel** — After coach mentions an action, refresh Tasks — item should appear.
4. **Confidence below 7** — Coach shrinks step; does not introduce a new skill in the same turn.

## What we store internally (for developers — optional reading)

When gates pass, the system records:

- **Target outcome** — the agreed success picture
- **Active micro-goal** — the locked small step
- **Micro-goal confidence** — last 1–10 score (need  $\geq 7$  to treat Phase Three execution as unlocked)

Trainers don't need to see these fields — they test through conversation and the Tasks page.

## Review questions for the team

1. Is "at least one key step before micro-stepping" the right bar, or do we want all three steps named upfront?
2. Should the coach **always** ask confidence 1–10, or only when the step is non-trivial?
3. Any scenario types where goal establishment should be shortened?

Write answers here: \_\_\_\_\_

*ShiftED AI · Goal establishment guide · July 2026*